

Start Here

Java Interview Prep — 2026 Edition · Learn & Excel

Welcome. This pack is **9 PDFs**, not one giant file — because no two buyers have the same interview situation. The right way to use this pack depends on three things: **when** your interview is, **what kind** of company, and **how senior** the role.

Spend 30 seconds on the diagnostic below. You'll know which file to open in under a minute.

The 30-second diagnostic

Question 1 — When is your interview?

Your timeline	Open these files, in this order
In the next 7 days	01 Top 50 → 07 Cheatsheet (print it)
1–3 weeks away	01 Top 50 → 02 Top 200 → 06 Spring + Hibernate + REST (if backend) → 07 Cheatsheet
1–3 months away	04 Core Library → 05 Scenario Library → 06 Spring + Hibernate + REST → finish with 01 Top 50 as a 3-day pre-interview revision
No specific interview — building skills	04 Core Library cover-to-cover. Read 2 chapters per week.

Question 2 — What kind of company are you interviewing at?

Company type	Focus on
Service MNC (TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, Cognizant)	02 Top 200 (Tier S + Tier A) + the "Service MNC patterns" section in 03 What Changed 2026
Indian product company (Razorpay, Cred, Swiggy, Meesho, Zerodha, Zomato)	02 Top 200 (all tiers) + 05 Scenario Library chapters on debug + design + concurrency. The bar is higher — they ask "design this" questions.
Early-stage startup	06 Spring + Hibernate + REST is critical — most startup Java roles are backend-heavy. Skim 04 for fundamentals.
GCC / global capability centre (Walmart Labs, Target, JP Morgan India, Wells Fargo)	Treat like product company. Add 05 design questions.
MAANG-style (Google, Meta, Amazon, Microsoft India)	This pack + LeetCode in parallel. This pack covers Java-specific + system-design-lite; LeetCode covers algorithm rounds.

Question 3 — What's your seniority level?

Years of experience	What to prioritize
0–2 years (Fresher / Junior)	04 Core Library chapters 1–7. Skip 05 design chapters and 06 deep Spring topics for now.
2–5 years (Mid)	All files. Focus your time on 04 chapters 5–13 + 05 Scenario Library + 06 Spring + Hibernate + REST .
5+ years (Senior)	04 chapter 13 (Java 17/21 modern features) + 05 Scenario Library (especially Design and Refactor sections) + 06 . Skim the basics, deep-dive the framework + architecture material.

The 5-day cram plan

You have a week. Here's how to spend it:

Day	Time investment	What to do
Day 1 (eve)	1 hour	Open 01 Top 50 . Read sections A and B (the Hot 10 + Collections Deep Cuts). Don't try to memorize — read for recognition.
Day 2 (eve)	1.5 hours	Finish 01 Top 50 sections C, D, E. Open 06 Spring + Hibernate + REST if your role is backend — skim the Spring Core chapter.
Day 3 (eve)	1 hour	Open 02 Top 200 . Read Tier S only (~50 Qs). These overlap with 01 but with deeper answers.
Day 4 (eve)	1 hour	Continue 02 Top 200 — Tier A (~80 Qs). Note any topics you keep hesitating on.
Day 5 (eve)	30 min	Re-read those weak topics from 04 Core Library . Don't add more — consolidate.
Day 6 (eve)	30 min	Print 07 Cheatsheet . Read it twice.
Day 7 (interview eve)	30 min max	Re-read 01 Top 50 Section A only (the Hot 10). Sleep early.
Interview day	—	Pen + 07 Cheatsheet in your bag. Don't read anything new.

The 30-day deep prep plan

You have a month. Here's the systematic version:

Week	Hours per week	What to do
Week 1 — Fundamentals	8–10	04 Core Library chapters 1–5 (Basics, OOP, Exception Handling, Collections, Strings). Read each chapter end-to-end. Mark any Q you couldn't answer in 30 seconds.
Week 2 — Depth + Concurrency	8–10	04 Core Library chapters 6–10 (Multithreading, JVM Internals, File I/O, Annotations, JDBC). Concurrency is the #1 topic where mid-level candidates fail — spend extra time on chapter 6.
Week 3 — Modern Java + Framework	8–10	04 Core Library chapters 11–13 (Java 8 Functional, Java 17/21 features) + all of 06 Spring + Hibernate + REST .
Week 4 — Scenarios + Polish	6–8	05 Scenario Library — work through the categories that match your role (Debug This Code if you're maintaining systems; Design This if you're leading projects). On the last 3 days, review 01 Top 50 + print 07 Cheatsheet .

Daily routine recommendation: pick 1 hour a day, same time. Better than 8 hours on Sunday + nothing else.

How to use the cheatsheet on interview day

The [07 Cheatsheet](#) is **one printable page**. It's not meant to be memorized — it's meant to be **glanced at 5 minutes before walking in**.

- Print it on A4 paper. Both sides if your printer supports it.
- Read it once on the cab ride / before logging into the Zoom call.
- During the interview itself, don't try to look at it. Trust that you've absorbed it.
- After the interview, write down 2 questions you couldn't answer well. Add them to your prep list for next time.

What's in each file (quick reference)

File	Use when
00 START HERE	(you are here)
01 Top 50 Most-Asked	Short runway — week-of-interview prep
02 Top 200 Most-Asked	2–3 week prep, want frequency-tiered coverage
03 What Changed in 2026	You want to know what's NEW this year so you don't get caught off-guard
04 Core Library (800 Qs)	Deep systematic prep — long runway
05 Scenario Library (800 Qs)	Round-2 and round-3 prep — design, debug, refactor
06 Spring + Hibernate + REST	Backend Java role — almost always required
07 Cheatsheet	Day-of reference — print and carry
08 Salary Range Map	After offer arrives, before you respond

If you're still unsure which file to open

Default to [01 Top 50](#). It's the highest-value-per-minute file in the pack regardless of your situation. Even if you only have 20 minutes today, the first 20 Qs of file [01](#) will materially change how you walk into your next interview.

Open it now. Spend 30 minutes. Come back to this diagnostic later if you need to re-plan.

Good luck. Go get it.

— The Learn & Excel team